



THE BLACK MADONNA

A retrospective by Petter Nallo

What is this?

In these pages you will find a retrospective of The Black Madonna—design and images of past editions, an interview with the creators, and letters from fans.



Characters, locations and incidents are portrayed from the metaphorical viewpoint of the *KULT: Divinity Lost* setting.

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THE BLACK MADONNA

HEW YEAR'S EVE 1941/42, THE lights go out in Leningrad's churches. The faces of the saints darken on the iconostasis. Twenty priests are found dead by their own hand the following morning. The same night, Dimi Nesterov finds his cousin Jurij dead in a cellar on Sadovaya Street. In the cellar is the cousin's little daughter, barely alive. Dimi drives her to an orphanage and leaves her there. On the way home, he meets a woman. She has a woolen mask over her face, a common way to protect against the cold, so he cannot see what she looks like. The woman tells Dimi that he should paint one last icon before he dies.

"An image of me," she says and removes the mask. He sees a completely black woman's face that reminds him of the darkened Madonna images he saw in his childhood. The woman disappears into the snow haze. Dimi goes home to his cramped apartment on Kaznatjeskaya Street and begins working on the icon of a Black Madonna.

introduction

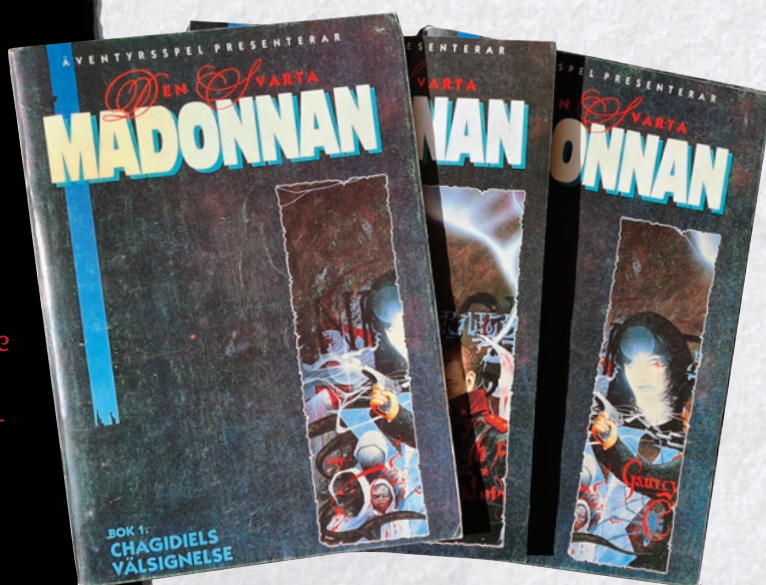
The Black Madonna has always carried a certain mystique. First written in the early 90s for *KULT*, the campaign was only ever released in Swedish and French — yet its reputation managed to ripple far beyond those borders. Among English-speaking fans, it became something of a legend. It wasn't until 2018 that *The Black Madonna* finally saw its long-awaited English release, adapted for *KULT: Divinity Lost*. Despite the decades that had passed, its dark, dream-like atmosphere still resonated.

It is a campaign deeply rooted in the spirit of its time — a child of the 90s, shaped by the political unease and post-Cold War paranoia that hung heavy in the air. It's not an easy campaign to run, something I learned the hard way as a 15-year-old gamesmaster. My attempt ended in disaster — the group was far more interested in unloading their Uzis or pulling off kung-fu stunts than diving into the story's dark depths. Yet even then, just reading the text left a mark on me. There was something special in those pages. Some scenes seemed to crackle with atmosphere — pure *KULT* at its most primal. Raw, unsettling, and unlike anything else at the time. Especially in Sweden, where roleplaying campaigns leaned towards more traditional, heroic fantasy or gothic horror with vampires and werewolves. *The Black Madonna* felt like a glimpse into another world — not without flaws, but brimming with imagination.

It was published in Swedish in 1991 and came in a box with 3 books. 2 containing the scenario and one smaller book with artworks depicting some of the NPCs and monsters in full color art by Tony Bagge.

In this retrospective we will dive into the creation of the campaign and how people have approached it as both creators as well as players.

Petter Nallo, 2025





Den svarta madonnan, 1991
Cover art by Peter Jones

INTERVIEW WITH THE CREATORS

To uncover how this strange, haunting journey came to life, I reached out to the two minds behind it — **Michael Petersén** and **Gunilla Jonsson**, the same duo who wrote the original edition of **KULT**. They invited me to their apartment in Stockholm — a fittingly atmospheric setting for our conversation.

It was one of those grey, misty days when the clouds seem to touch the ground, and the distant skyscrapers of the city dissolve into the haze. The weather outside stood in sharp contrast to the warmth inside their home. Not surprisingly, after decades of working at the Science Fiction Bookstore, their apartment was a treasure trove of books. Shelves lined every wall, filled with novels, role-playing games, and all kinds of strange lore. Over a comforting lunch of homemade chili, followed by a traditional fika with coffee and pastries, we settled into the living room — me on the sofa, Michael and Gunilla in their familiar writing armchairs.

The Black Madonna, they told me, had been born alongside **KULT** itself. The campaign was test-played while the core rules were still being written — a mirror to the world they were constructing from scratch. Later expansions like *Legions of Darkness*, *Fallen Angels*, and *Tarotium* followed, but The Black Madonna was something different — sprawling, ambitious, and deeply narrative-driven.

"It was our attempt to create something that wasn't just a series of adventures," Michael said. *"We wanted it to be more like a novel — something that told a story players could step into."*

Gunilla nodded. *"I think that's why it stayed with people. It wasn't just about solving puzzles or fighting enemies. It was about what happened to your character along the way — how they were changed by what they experienced."*

The campaign's mythological status might have grown over the years, but sitting there with its creators, the process behind it felt remarkably down-to-earth — two writers trying to craft something that pushed the boundaries of what role-playing games could be. What they didn't know at the time was that they were setting the blueprint for how **KULT** would be remembered — not just as a game, but as something far darker and more literary than most of its contemporaries.

The Black Madonna's influence was not just felt in its dark themes but also in its surprising origins. Set against the backdrop of post-Wall Germany, it introduced a world far removed from the typical RPG landscapes of the early 90s. As the campaign unfolded, players found themselves navigating neo-Nazi hangouts, mental hospitals, and the crumbling remnants of the Soviet Union—eventually descending into Hell and eerie Dream Worlds. It was a far cry from what one might expect in a Swedish RPG.

Gunilla reflects on the origins of the campaign: *"We wanted a dark backstory, but we didn't want to touch on the Holocaust. So, we gravitated toward the siege of Leningrad during World War II. We had this notion that God died with that moment in history."*

Michael chimes in: *"It felt a bit exotic to us. We had no personal ties to that tragedy. Even though it was a dreadful event with mass deaths, cannibalism, it didn't carry the same sensitivity as the Holocaust."*

The image of the Leningrad cathedral's candles snuffed out simultaneously stuck with them—a symbol of divine death, one that resonated deeply within the Christian themes at the heart of **KULT**. It was a fitting scene to anchor the campaign's eerie atmosphere, a place where dark faith and decay intertwined.

Though the bulk of the campaign's lore is steeped in that haunting history, there's a strange contrast in its origins. Much of it was originally intended for a different project entirely—*Master of Shadows* (Skuggornas Mästare). This was a game Michael and Gunilla had created themselves, an action-packed detective game with agents and ninjas, worlds apart from the somber, existential terror of **KULT**. Yet, the action elements, like foreign airbases and covert missions, found their way into The Black Madonna's DNA.

Michael laughs, admitting, *"Yeah, those are my fault. It's from a campaign I ran in Södertälje. We looked at it and thought, 'There's something here. Why not infuse it into a KULT campaign?'"*

Gunilla adds, *"Exactly. Let's take what we have and just inject it with Death Angels and Orthodox Icons."*

Even **KULT** itself took cues from *Master of Shadows*, borrowing rule system elements, weaponry, and other details. But this wasn't a decision solely driven by the creators. Target Games, the company behind **KULT**, also pushed for the game to incorporate more action elements. It was a unique fusion of two distinct atmospheres, creating something entirely new.

When Leningrad emerged as a central element of the story, everything clicked into place, and the idea of The Black Madonna took on a new life, Michael recalls. *"It suddenly opened up whole new concepts. We could connect East Germany, Russia, neo-Nazis, and the current events of the 90s. That's when it really came alive."*

They wanted a clear starting point, so the campaign began in Hamburg and Berlin, with the story of Magda created specifically for **KULT**. But they were determined not to let it fall into a typical detective narrative. Having played a lot of Call of Cthulhu, they envisioned **Kult** as more of an action movie laced with horror. Michael and Gunilla also felt that Berlin and Hamburg, with their international vibe, added a layer of depth that places like Stockholm could not.

Fredrik Malmberg, CEO of Target Games, wanted the campaign to appeal to a global audience. *"He told us, 'Don't even mention that Sweden exists. They'll just mistake it for Switzerland,'"* Gunilla says, laughing.

For Michael and Gunilla, Berlin wasn't just a setting—it was a city they were deeply connected to. *"We both love the city,"* Michael says. *"It was the birthplace of Metropolis. In the 90s, after the fall of the Wall, it was a strange place. Some streets just stopped, ending in dead ends. Parts of the city felt desolate, in ruins."* The atmosphere of Berlin's fractured, post-Cold War landscape mirrored the world they were trying to evoke.

Looking back, they both feel that if they could revisit the campaign, they would have expanded the beginning. They wanted the players to have more time to explore both the setting and



Photos from the day
of the interview in
Stockholm.

January
2025.



their characters before the curse struck and thrust them into the heart of the plot. *"Back in the 90s, we knew the audience would mostly be teenage boys, which is why we created the Curse—to keep them engaged and moving through the campaign,"* Michael explains.

But Gunilla believes that Target Games, while supportive, also felt they had crafted something too highbrow. *"They probably hoped it would be even more targeted at the teenage audience,"* she adds.

Inspiration

At the time, Michael and Gunilla hadn't played many horror games beyond *Call of Cthulhu* and *Chill*, so the idea of *KULT* was entering new territory for them. *"There weren't that many horror games in that time that were even closely similar to KULT,"* Michael notes. They felt that to truly capture the atmosphere they wanted, the game needed a unique storytelling approach—one that would immerse players in a way that allowed them to be active participants, co-creators in the narrative. *KULT* needed its own horror logic.

"We got a lot of inspiration from movies like Hellbound: Hellraiser II, Hellraiser, and also Re-Animator and other movies by Stuart Gordon," Michael says. Gunilla elaborates, *"But they are mostly scenes that are stacked on top of each other. It almost feels like a journey through dreams. Slightly surreal and very railroaded if you would make it into an RPG campaign."*

Leningrad, Beyond the Dream

One of the most memorable aspects of *The Black Madonna* for Michael and Gunilla is the creation of Dream Leningrad, a city frozen in time and trapped in eternal cold, where frozen bodies line the streets. It's a part of the campaign that still fills them with pride today. *"Reality, the Dream, and Inferno just melded together there,"* Michael says, reflecting on how the three realms blend seamlessly in that nightmarish vision of Leningrad.

For the players who delved into Magda's backstory and the stories of her Russian friends—children who had endured the horrors of the Siege of Leningrad—the moment they enter this frozen, dreamlike city becomes especially powerful. *"When they come to this nightmarish place, it makes it extra memorable,"* Michael adds, the weight of the characters' pasts deepening the atmosphere.

Nazis, Nepharites, and The Abuser of Children

KULT as well as *The Black Madonna* stirred controversy when it was released in Sweden, and it's easy to see why. At the time, Sweden's TTRPG scene was relatively innocent. Players were used to fantasy games like *Drakar och Demoner* or *Mutant*, or horror games where they faced off against classic monsters—vampires, mummies, werewolves. Then came *The Black Madonna*, introducing players to Nazis, sure, but also to nepharites—twisted creatures born from abuse and cannibalism during the

Siege of Leningrad. And if that wasn't enough, there was Chagidiel, the Death Angel, an abuser of children, whose incarnation was a strict father figure with a belt and an ill-fitting suit.

"Far from classic monsters, especially when the players were mostly teenage boys," Michael says, acknowledging the boundary-pushing nature of the campaign.

But for them, it wasn't quite so strange. *"Well, I mean, our group of players were in their 30s, so for us it wasn't as unusual,"* Michael explains. The story, especially its focus on an orphanage in Leningrad, meant that Chagidiel's presence was deeply connected to the plot. *"Also, it was a lot in the news in the 90s about orphaned children in Eastern Europe. So it sort of added to the general plot. And those orphanages were truly terrible, so in many ways it was part of the zeitgeist."*

The nepharites, though, stood out in a different way. While most campaigns of the era would have treated such creatures as enemies to be defeated, *The Black Madonna* made them tragic figures, victims in their own right. This introduced a morally gray area that was rare for role-playing games in the early 90s. *"The three nepharites were, of course, inspired by the cenobites from Hellraiser, and especially the background of Pinhead,"* Michael says. *"He was also a victim. And in Hellraiser and Hellbound, they're not evil, per se."*

It was never intended for players to attack the nepharites. *"We never saw KULT as a monster game,"* Gunilla clarifies. The nepharites' role was to serve as remnants of Leningrad, much like Magda and her Russian companions. *"They are, in a way, victims too,"* she adds. This blending of victimhood with horror was what set *The Black Madonna* apart, making it a uniquely unsettling experience.

Methods to their Madness

When Michael and Gunilla were writing *KULT* and *The Black Madonna*, they lived in a modest 39m² apartment just outside of Stockholm, surrounded by books. *"There were books everywhere,"* Michael recalls. This was in the days before the internet, so to research, they had to rely on library visits, borrowing books on various subjects—from guidebooks about Berlin and Hamburg to historical accounts of the Siege of Leningrad.

"We wrote it down on a PC, our first one," says Michael. Before that, they had an old computer with a 10MB hard drive, which felt like a luxury at the time. *"Yes, I remember we used a software called Word-Star,"* Gunilla adds.

While most of their writing was done on a computer, their brainstorming sessions were more tactile. They would frequent cafés, armed with separate notebooks where they jotted down ideas during their fika breaks. *"A method we still use to this day,"* says Michael. Gunilla adds, *"But being able to have shared documents on the computer has at least doubled our work speed."*

The Black Madonna Then and Now

The Black Madonna today, serves as a snapshot of a bygone era. *"It's even more interesting today,"* Gunilla reflects, *"when you look back at the 90s, with only one remaining superpower in the world, and the belief that liberalism was the political ideology that would solve everything."* She also points to small details in the game, such as rooms with tables and ashtrays, which serve as subtle reminders of the 90s. *"So to play it now takes you back to that time."*

"When we wrote it, we didn't know the Soviet Union would collapse," Gunilla adds. *"It just happened."*



Michael Petersén and Gunilla Jonsson
Creators of KULT



La Madone Noire, 2005
Cover art by Aurélien Police



Magda in La Madone Noire, 2005
Artist unknown



The Black Madonna, 2018
Standard edition over art by
Bastien Lecouffe-Deharme
Black edition symbol by Petter Nallo



The Black Madonna, 2018
Cover art by Bastien Lecouffe-Deharme



Dream Leningrad
Illustration by Anton Semenov for *The Black Madonna* (2018)



WORD AND ART FROM PETER BERGTING

Peter Bergting is a fantasy illustrator whose distinctive work has graced numerous roleplaying games including *Shadowrun*, *Drakar och Demoner*, *Mutant*, and of course, *KULT*.

In the United States, Bergting has produced several graphic novels for major publishers including *Image Comics*, *IDW*, and *Dark Horse*, collaborating with authors like Joe R. Lansdale and Richard Morgan. His artistic reach extends to hundreds of book covers, including iconic works such as *Ronja Rövardotter*, *The Lord of the Rings*, and *The Golden Compass*.

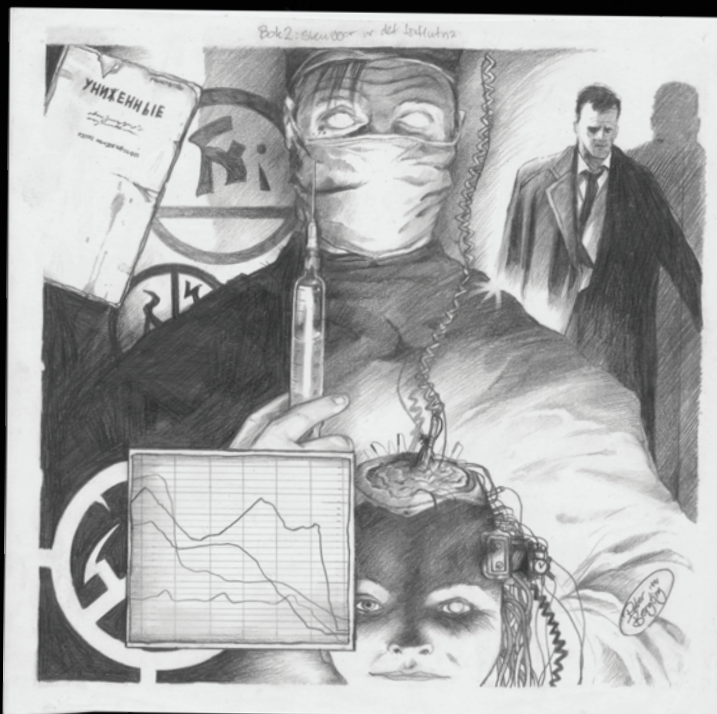
Peter Bergting was also the main artist for *The Black Madonna* in 1991.

"I had just been discharged from military service," Peter recalls. "I was sitting on the train to Karlstad for my first Film Studies lectures when I sketched the initial concepts for what would become *The Black Madonna*. The *Kid Eternity* miniseries was a massive inspiration for those first images. Duncan Fegredo's style of drawing at that time was just amazing."

The artworks that introduce each chapter have a near photorealistic style. "I can't recall if they specifically requested near-photorealistic images for the chapter artwork, but that was certainly my artistic vision for the project."

There was a plan for a stark visual contrast for the book. "I created the illustrations in black and white with blood-red accents. The original plan was to have these colors separated in the printing process. But that didn't work out in the end. Technical limitations meant everything became monochrome throughout. That period was really a time of great experimentation for me," he reflects. "I was constantly testing new techniques and forms of expression."

What you see here and in the following pages are some of Peter's artwork for the Swedish edition of *The Black Madonna*.

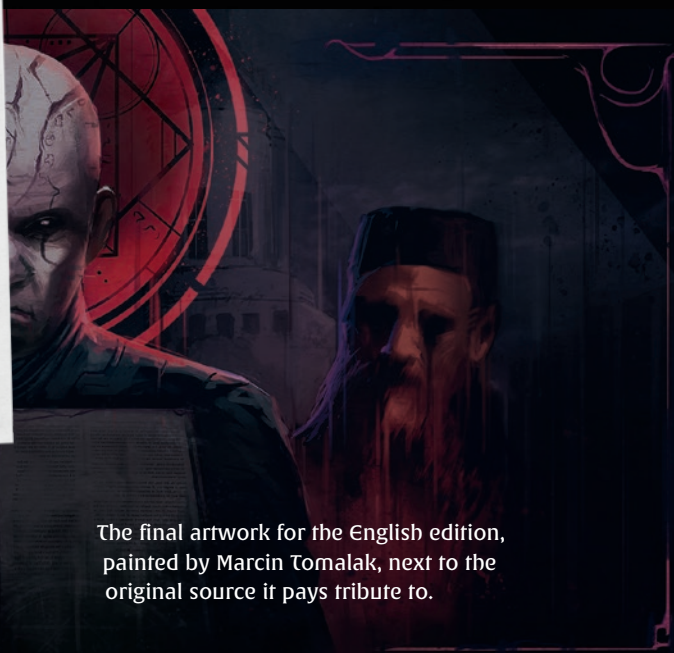
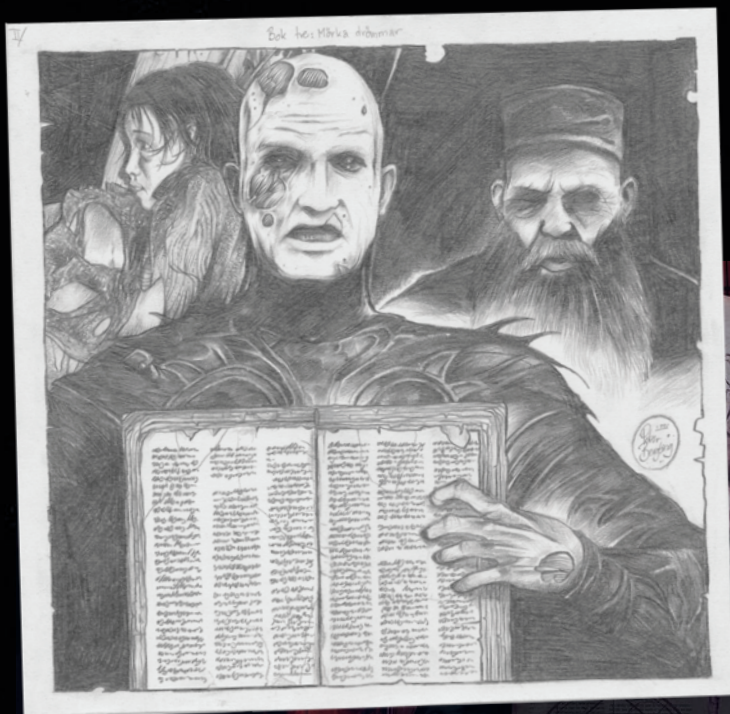




FROM HELMGAST:

The artwork for the Swedish and French editions was a major inspiration for the English edition, where many elements are given new form as a way to pay tribute to the game's origins. With these side by side, you may glimpse the creative process behind the new edition.

The colored illustrations you see is by Marcin Tomalak, for the English edition.



The final artwork for the English edition, painted by Marcin Tomalak, next to the original source it pays tribute to.



Bakgrunden



konstens förbannelse



Leningrad 1941



Dödsängeln nedskiger



De 900 dagarna



Nyårsmakten



Madonnan Vaknar



Madonnan lukemäärä



Mies i katedraalen

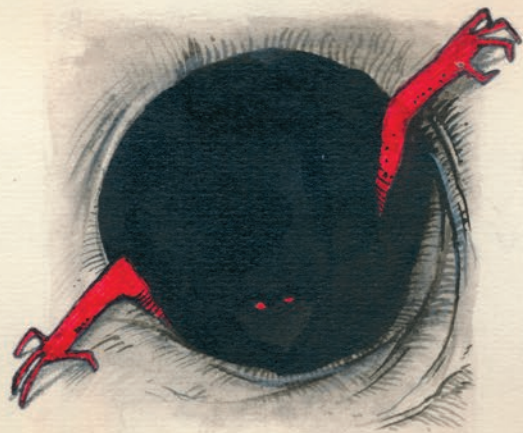


Öösaargens lyht

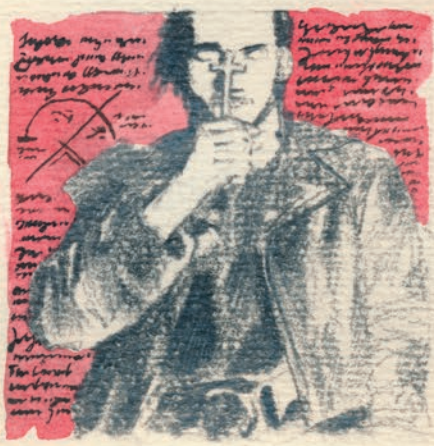
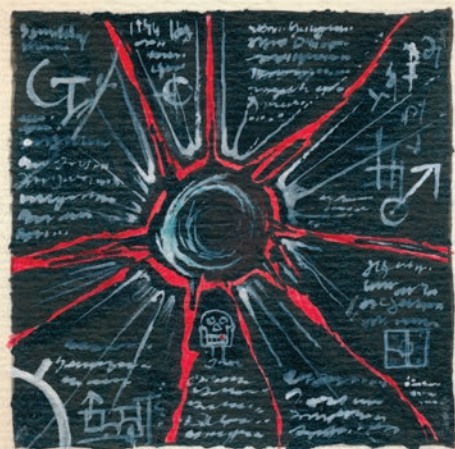
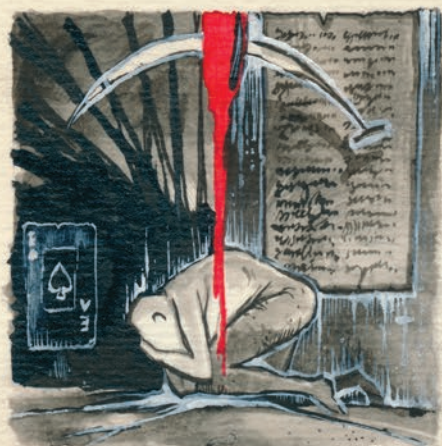


En liktor föds





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21

These artworks were created by Tony Bagge for the Swedish edition of *The Black Madonna*, also a great inspiration for the illustrations you see in the English edition.



VOICES FROM THE RED MOON

Red Moon Roleplaying is an *ENnie Award*-winning podcast known for playing roleplaying games set in dark, atmospheric worlds. The team consists of *Craig Austin*, *Mattiaz Fredriksson*, and *Hjalmar Nordén*. Their focus on mood and drama has often drawn comparisons to radio theatre.

The first campaign they played—and the foundation of *Red Moon Roleplaying*—was *The Black Madonna*. Their extensive 35-episode run offers listeners a deep insight into how the campaign can be brought to life, whether at the table or simply as pure listening pleasure.

Here, the Red Moon team shares their voices and reflections on *The Black Madonna*.

Mattiaz

Whenever the topic of the best Swedish RPG campaigns comes up on gaming forums, *The Black Madonna* is almost always listed among the top three. Its dark subject matter and ties to real-world historical events make it stand out. Over the decades, countless gaming groups have delved into the tragic past of Magda Orlova. In recent years, the campaign has gained renewed relevance, with the rise of the far right and a revanchist Russia echoing themes that feel ripped straight from the headlines.

Yet in 2017, no actual play podcasts had tackled the campaign.

We knew from listening to many other shows that you only get one chance to make a first impression — and you'd better choose a game and story that people care about. For us, the choice was obvious: *The Black Madonna* would be our debut campaign, and we hoped it would allow us to introduce ourselves to the world with a story that had never been told in podcast form before.

To capture the right tone, we drew inspiration from films that mirrored aspects of the story. *Good Bye, Lenin!* gave us insight into life in East Germany and the fall of the Berlin Wall. *The Ninth Gate* influenced Craig's portrayal of the occultist Carver, while *American Psycho* helped shape the world of Hjalmar's character, Björn, and the shallow yuppie culture he inhabited.

The investigation of Magda's flat — her tragic fate, and the creeping realization that her friends were involved in something truly sinister — helped build a mounting sense of tension. Layered on top of that were our characters' personal demons and backstories, which added emotional momentum as we moved through the early chapters.

It was in those early chapters, when the supernatural remained a subtle, plausibly deniable undercurrent, that we were able to establish our characters and help the audience form genuine emotional bonds with them. The locations were deeply atmospheric — the Neo-Nazi headquarters stood out as particularly chilling. And then there was Jenkins, the enigmatic cat, who became an unexpected fan favorite. Listeners speculated endlessly about his true nature.

As we ventured into the dream world and navigated the horrors of wartime Leningrad, the campaign gradually embraced the madness that *KULT* allows players to explore. And yet, throughout it all, Björn and Carver remained loyal to one another, each ultimately making great sacrifices to stop the incarnations of Chagidiel from achieving their goals.

Hjalmar

Our playthrough of the *Black Madonna* campaign was my first real introduction to the *KULT* universe and Mattiaz was very keen for us as players not to know too much, if anything, of what went on beyond the illusion. I remember never fully knowing what to expect and having a hard time understanding what my character was seeing, just like he himself would have. These days I could point out what kind of monstrosity was before us, from my knowledge of the *KULT*iverse, but back then it was all a puzzle. On the note of not knowing what to expect, I remember a fond moment some time into the campaign when my character, Björn, went to check the boot of his car. Despite there having been some time since my driver was killed and found in another car's boot, Mattiaz immediately took the bait and as

I opened it up, he casually let me know that in it was "...your dead driver". I remember crying out a spontaneous "fuck you!", an exclamation that to this day I'm not sure was Björn aiming towards the world or Hjalmar aiming it towards an excellent GM who was messing with him. If I wasn't expecting the worst, then why even check the boot?

The way the campaign was intertwined with our character's personal fates makes it hard to say which bits were part of the original written material and what was Mattiaz's blend of the two. That said, there were several things I'm pretty sure was there from the start that made this so memorable. Among them was the time pressure, the body horror and the sense of deteriorating without knowing what we were really looking for. Was our condition curable? If anyone claimed they could help us, were they telling the Truth? Another element was the changes of scenery and slow descent into sheer disbelief of what was happening around us, such as the scenes at the sanitarium where we encountered things that were beyond humanity, amazingly later on contrasted with a raid on a military base (something I understand was almost mandatory in the writers' campaigns of the time). The things



during those scenes created fantastic clashes between the distorted reality of James calling upon the rising burnt bodies of Purgatides and Björn's de facto military prowess when he was suddenly manning a fighter jet. Of course this was helped by Mattiaz's wish for a proper dogfight.

There was also something special about Craig not knowing my character's real archetype, initially thinking I was playing a Careerist when in fact I was a Ronin, hiding from my past. A past which hunted me partly in the shape of my Rival disadvantage, which then turned into an unresolved love story and finally romance under the black sun of Metropolis. The separation of Carver and Björn just prior to that was truly heart-wrenching, and the fate of James Carver presented an indescribably sad and strong ending, whereas what became of Björn and Vova was left a lot more open.

I always love the reactions of our fans, but what we got back then left a special first recognition that's hard to compare with anything further down the line. It was early on for the team, and we had no idea what to expect in the shape of support, but the loud voices of the few that decided to comment were very touching. It paved way for starting our Patreon and for our Q&A sessions "Ask for the Moon" which lead to a lot of talks about roleplaying, character and scenario creation. I'm immensely grateful for Helmgast sending those early handouts (I remember skipping between PDF's and barebone word documents trying to make sense of what I was supposed to create) and their belief in what we were trying to make. It sometimes feels like they knew better than us how great it would all turn out to be. Creating Björn from all of that, sneaking in tidbits of Hjalmar's own personality like the interest in psychedelics and a love for Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles, made for a very special first step into what we were trying to make.

Craig

Coming into the KULT universe through the Black Madonna was certainly an exciting experience. Knowing nothing of the setting before this game and coming in as an inquisitive academic made all the horrors hit harder. I didn't truly know what to expect. I was not disappointed in the end and have many fond memories of slowly unraveling that first mystery and encountering some of its horrors. Not truly knowing what to expect made things even more exciting. That initial horror

book certainly will haunt me to this day. My most favorite moments? Slowly losing my very soul to corrupt occult powers of course! And that dramatic finale!

The Black Madonna is the campaign that built Red Moon Role-playing. It laid the foundation for our voice in the actual play space. With the incredible support of *Helmgast*, we connected with an audience that values transgressive horror, listeners who don't use humor as a shield, but lean into the darkness. We told a story that embraced pain, sacrifice, and the terrible beauty of the unknown. And we've never looked back.



• Name Björn von Krusenstierna

• Archetype The Ronin

• Occupation Investor and philanthropist

KULT
♦ DIVINITY LOST ♦

Choose your player character's occupation from the archetype, or invent one of your choosing.

• Appearance Suit, mundane face, challenging eyes, empty smile

Select from your archetype or come up with your own distinguishing features for your character.

• Attributes

Assign the modifiers +2, +1, and +0 to the three passive attributes: Fortitude, Reflexes, and Willpower.

Assign the modifiers +3, +2, +1, +1, +0, -1, and -2 to the other seven active attributes: Charisma, Coolness, Intuition, Perception, Reason, Soul, and Violence.



• Dark Secrets

Secret Past

Choose 1 or more dark secrets.

• Disadvantages

Nemesis
Nightmares

Choose 2 disadvantages.

• Advantages

Exit strategy
Chameleon
Weapon Master (Gunplay)

Choose 3 advantages from your archetype.

• Relations

Single with lots of casual sex

+1 Tomisław Malon - Artist who is always up for debauchery

Relationship with Magda Orlova

0 Knows her through her journalism

• Name James Carver

• Archetype The Occultist

• Occupation Rare Book Dealer

KULT

♦ DIVINITY LOST ♦

Choose your player character's occupation from the archetype, or invent one of your choosing.

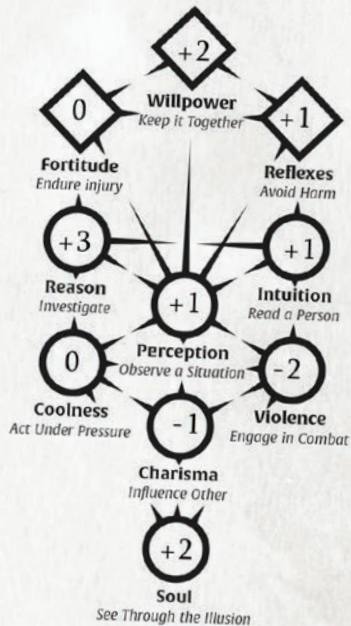
• Appearance Blonde hair to the shoulders, stubble, thin

Select from your archetype or come up with your own distinguishing features for your character.

• Attributes

Assign the modifiers +2, +1, and +0 to the three passive attributes: Fortitude, Reflexes, and Willpower.

Assign the modifiers +3, +2, +1, +1, +0, -1, and -2 to the other seven active attributes: Charisma, Coolness, Intuition, Perception, Reason, Soul, and Violence.



• Dark Secrets

Flashbacks

Choose 1 or more dark secrets.

• Disadvantages

Stalker
Nightmares

Choose 2 disadvantages.

• Advantages

Sixth sense
Dabbler in the occult
Occult library
Thirst for knowledge

Choose 3 advantages from your archetype.

• Relations

Alone with few friends
+1 Jenkins the cat, a grey tabby

Relationship with Magda Orlova
0 Got to know her through her antique bookstore



A WORD FROM THE PUBLISHER: FREDRIK MALMBERG ON THE BLACK MADONNA

Fredrik Malmberg, who served as the head of Äventyrsspel when they commissioned both KULT and The Black Madonna, shares his brief reflections on this legendary campaign:

"I remember it took a long time to get it finished. But it became so big that we could not afford to translate it. After that experience, we tried to make shorter scenarios like *Fallen Angels* and *Taroticum*.

It felt good to have published a campaign that became legendary. I think its status has a lot to do with the fact that it was never published in English. But it was truly an impressive product—a box containing three separate books."



Illustration for
the English
Edition
by Marcin
Tomalak.

TORBEN HALVORSEN RYGG ON TRANSLATING THE BLACK MADONNA

Torben Halvorsen Rygg ran *kult-rpg.com* and *The Last Cycle* KULT forums in the early 2000s. His community involvement led French publisher 7eme Cercle to ask him to translate *The Black Madonna* from Swedish to English so that they could then translate it to French. It is Torben's translation to English that was the foundation for the Helmcast edition of the *Black Madonna*, in English, after edits by Jason Fryer.

"I was very involved in the KULT community, running *kult-rpg.com* and *The Last Cycle* forums. We had many admins and moderators in an active community with competitions for adventures, art, music, and stories. I don't remember exactly why they asked me, but I think it was because I wrote some adventures and had interviewed some of the original creators."

Torben ran the Swedish version of the *Black Madonna* with his gaming group in the late 90s. "We had a blast playing it. I believe it was a campaign where players could grasp the underlying plot by the end, making more sense than scenarios like *Taroticum*."

He emphasized the historical setting: "It needs to be set in 1991 to work with the Soviet Union's collapse and Germany's post-reunification uncertainty. Not having mobile phones increased character vulnerability. My group was always action-oriented, with some players min-maxing characters for combat. *The Black Madonna* allows for many random encounters outside the main plot. My players also enjoy playing out daily routines to build character attachment, but this time we focused more on the main storyline."

The campaign left a strong impression: "For us it was our peak RPG experience, but we spent more than triple the hours of other groups. Players were clearly moved and disturbed by scenes like the dream orphanage."

Torben also introduced new players to RPGs through this campaign around 2005. "I GMed half the story with another group, including two new players who were blown away and still play RPGs now. They had a hilarious incident with three critical failures while climbing down a fire escape, creating some laughter between the horror moments."

An interesting footnote: "There was a rumor that someone distributed my translation among friends because they were frustrated that 7eme Cercle never published the English version I had made."

A RETROSPECTIVE FROM OLOF FALK WHO RAN THE BLACK MADONNA

It is November 2024. Once again, tanks and rockets loom ominously on the horizon. Ordinary people huddle together in the comfort of their homes, desperate for shelter from the outside world. Again and again, they turn to the tyrants who promise wealth and safety, while draining the planet of its last lifeblood to keep their own bellies sated. Somehow, we always seem willing to let the Others be thrown to the wolves, provided we are given the option to avert our eyes. Looking outside, while the storm clouds gather and the thunder rolls in the distance, it is hard to question that we live in a world where the sun has set.

I took my first steps into the bleak world of KULT sometime just before the turn of the new millennium. The sinister resonance of that name, however, had sunk its hooks in my mind some years before then. Rumours of impressionable youth and children slowly changing into the monsters they revealed in portraying, before the eyes of horrified parents. Stories of dark fantasies blending into reality, beckoning those who heard the call to enter another world. For the most part, constructions of sensationalist media, and of a parental generation trying to deal with something they couldn't understand, of course. For a time, the keepers of the illusion succeeded well in making sure I wouldn't come near such dangerous influence. That is, until *Target Games* (formerly *Äventyrsspel*) collapsed, and their surplus stock reached the bargain shelves of mainstream outlet stores. That was when I first came into contact with the KULT collectible card game. And consequently, that was where whatever little pocket money I could scrape together disappeared. The connection between those small packets of cards and that horrid ghost of the past was relatively easy to hide. The cards offered vivid glimpses into a supremely dark and malignant, dreamlike, and frightening universe, blending the surreal stuff of nightmares with horrors of the waking world. But vivid as they were, glimpses remained, with only an advertisement in the rulebook testifying that once, there had also been a fully fledged role-playing game named KULT, that offered further entry into this dark world to those who dared step in.

When I was finally old enough to have real money of my own, it proved frustratingly difficult to track down those out-of-print books. This was in the years when an Internet connection (let alone a stable, high-speed connection) was nowhere near the household commodity it would soon become. Very few traces of the KULT RPG were at all possible to find back then, except for hearsay, rumours, and (if one was lucky) stories and memories from people who had played the game in its glory days. I devoured all that there was to learn, although some images, names and concepts stuck more than others. One such name was The Black Madonna, rumoured among many to be one of the best, and most terrifying, roleplaying campaigns of all time. I had no idea what lurked behind that name, aside from ominous connotations to games of malignant spirit summoning

that we used to play in front of dark mirrors as children. Given that the game had a reputation for dark rituals, and of twisting young minds, there was obviously something very enticing and foreboding in that connection. Eventually, I managed to get hold of the second edition sourcebook and the GM screen (which included three pre-written scenarios) and began to run shorter games with close friends, while also experimenting with writing scenarios of my own. But the knowledge of the first edition lingered, beheld by many as the original, uncensored, and very darkest version of KULT. And associated with that first edition was also, of course, the mysterious Black Madonna.

Thanks to the emergence of online auction sites in Sweden, I eventually managed to get hold of an all but complete collection of practically everything published for KULT in Swedish – including, of course, the Black Madonna. The content and writing of those first edition books was dark and vibrant beyond all expectations. I still remember carrying them with me at almost all times in those days. I never grew tired of reading them, again and again. Somehow, there always seemed to be new ideas to discover, new rabbit holes to follow. It was also around this time that I discovered The Last Cycle forums, brimming with creative souls, elaborating and expanding the mystery and mythology even further through text, music, art. The inspiration, imagination and existential depth seemed almost without boundaries. And all this around a dead, niche, 1990s roleplaying game.

The Black Madonna turned out to be a beast completely different from the images I had painted in my own mind, although by no means less frightening. Compared to anything officially or unofficially released, I was entirely convinced that it was the quintessential KULT story. Its bleak horror masterfully traversed time and space, blending ghosts of the past with contemporary urban decay and timeless black magic. Revenants of totalitarian horrors, returning to life in a bleak and newly unshackled Eastern Europe, trying to find its way in the new world. Lost souls bearing witness to atrocities old and new, caught in a web of intrigues woven by cosmic forces far beyond their understanding. Gods, devils and humans, vying over centuries for spiritual dominion over an unfathomable Illusion. Vile, agonizing and repulsive terrors of the flesh, converging with those of psychological torture and authoritarian abuse. Regardless of which brand of horror one preferred, The Black Madonna had it all covered, and it did not shy away from any depths. But all the while, it remained unplayed, challenging and demanding in scope as it was. For a relatively inexperienced gamemaster such as myself, setting up the campaign seemed daunting, let alone finding players who were willing to undertake it. In my circle of friends, I was quite alone to have an interest in that kind of horror, not to mention willing to commit the time needed to pursue such a mammoth campaign. It thus remained unplayed, although thoroughly read, over and over again. My focus was instead placed on trying to bring scenarios of my own writing to life. But the Black Madonna remained on its shelf, ever beckoning and defiant.

Years passed, role-playing groups dispersed, and former players (including myself) were forced to prioritize trivialities such as career and family building. For long, I assumed that the daydreams and wondrous mental journeys made possible by collaborative storytelling were things of the past. At this time, few friends seemed even vaguely interested, even fewer could

afford the time. Many dark years would follow. It was not until 2018, after a resurgent interest in board gaming in a circle of old and new acquaintances, that a light sprung from the shadows, so to speak. A friend in this circle suggested trying out the Genlab Alpha scenario for *Mutant: Year Zero*, released a few years before. Aside from myself, he was the only one among us with experience of having played role-playing games before, although he also had endured many years of hiatus from playing. Rediscovering roleplaying in that campaign was a great experience, and the structure of the game demonstrated how even a relatively complex story could be streamlined to accommodate the schedules of full-time workers – even parents. The new roleplayers in our group were very excited to have discovered the RPG hobby, and those of us who hadn't played for several years felt rejuvenated and joyful in having rediscovered it. And as it happened, our conclusion of Genlab Alpha coincided with the Kickstarter delivery of *KULT: Divinity Lost*. And with that, an updated, refined release of the *Black Madonna*. I quickly decided to take the opportunity and suggest what we should play next. All of us being avid horror fans, my group very enthusiastically accepted the offer, with myself having the honour of serving as gamemaster.

Reading through the adaptation of the *Black Madonna* for *KULT: Divinity Lost*, it did not take long for me to determine that this was most probably the definitive version of the scenario. While keeping to the original story, masterfully penned by Gunilla Jonsson and Mikael Petersen, the scenario had been restructured, expanded, and updated to accommodate the perspectives and expectations of contemporary players and gamemasters. The scenario, while still incredibly rich and complex in terms of themes and plot, had been made far more manageable than the more intimidating original version. While keeping with the largely non-linear form of the original scenario (that is, within the different acts), the editors had obviously taken great care in partitioning it into comprehensive scenes. This made it easy for the gamemaster to prepare them in advance, regardless of the order of how the players chose to engage with them.

I was thoroughly impressed with the amount of work that had apparently gone into revising this scenario. Not least so by the introductory sections, which offered not only concrete recommendations for running the scenario and tailoring it to the player group, but also more flavorful recommendations, such as movies,

documentaries, music and imagery to inspire the GM and immerse the players. In the early planning, one of the most rewarding parts was delving into the different recommended media, as well as trailing off in doing my own research on specific topics that corresponded with the themes of the story. Doing close research on revolutionary Soviet poetry, Nazi occultism, and life in Eastern Europe before and after the fall of the Berlin Wall was well worth the time, and added an immense amount of flavour to the campaign. I was also fortunate enough to have a particularly engaged group of players, who invested considerable time and effort in developing the player characters. It is always a good sign for a campaign when a player does not only invest considerable amounts of time in writing the background for the character, but also takes the time to compile music playlists, perfectly set in the era, and flawlessly conveying the feel of the character to the GM. As far as possible, I wanted to make sure that all the efforts made by the players would be rewarded in the story. To my great appreciation, the editors of the campaign had also made the choice to conclude the story by suggesting a logical (and exquisitely phrased) ending. The original version had concluded by simply suggesting some hooks to continue the story after the campaign, which I assume reflected the standard for pre-written scenarios back then. I myself was never much of a fan of this, preferring instead that all good stories should have a clear ending. The one presented in the revised *Black Madonna* did not disappoint. It cast a somber reflection of our own times against Europe's dark past, conveying the eerie realization that not that much might have changed, despite our strong convictions of the contrary. Inspired by our experience with Genlab Alpha, I decided to run the scenario largely out of the box with few revisions, other than additions to accommodate the player characters, and perhaps to add some extra flavour. I wanted to find the middle ground between the new and the old – I wanted the story itself to feel like old *KULT*, but amplified by all the quality of life updates offered by the new system, encouraging collaborative storytelling rather than number exercises.

So how did the players fare in the scenario? That is probably a story that is better told another time, and in another forum. Suffice it to say that our collaborative story created many heartfelt memories which will remain firmly with me, and – so I sincerely believe – with my player group as well. Instead of recounting the details of the story – which I think will look vastly different in each player group undertaking this journey – I instead thought I'd provide a few recommendations that I would probably have benefited from if I would run the campaign for the first time, or even run it again with a new group of players.

- ◆ Above all, find the right group of players. Although this might seem trivial, I really can't stress it enough. The *Black Madonna* is a grand campaign in every aspect of the term, and as such it demands considerable amounts of time and effort from all involved to make the best of it. Although the book structure makes it easy for the GM to keep track, running the scenario is immensely facilitated if the everyone takes the responsibility of making notes and remembering what they did the previous session. Our campaign took several years, which included a pandemic, parenthood and relocations, among other life-changing events. It became increasingly hard to demand that all involved should remember in detail what occurred during the sessions,

which sometimes happened with months inbetween. This situation was significantly alleviated by having the most devoted, most collaborative player group imaginable. Thus: Make sure that your players know what they will be up against from the outset, and make sure that they all feel included and involved in the whole duration of the story.

- ◆ As advised in the book, take the time to do some research – the more, the better, I would argue. There is no limit to the amount of flavour and atmosphere that can be added by carefully sprinkling the story with just the right amount of historical knowledge and niche facts. I would argue that a large part of the immersion lies in the details, especially when it comes to recreating a bygone era.
- ◆ Although the story is centered around intrigues involving major, external forces, make sure that the characters are allowed to have their own stories within the grand campaign. Make sure that they have something to lose, something to be torn away from, something to fight for. Keeping these perspectives make the existential plunge the characters will have to go through extra daunting.
- ◆ Don't underestimate the power of a good soundtrack. My personally preferred way is to include a selection of tunes with different emotions, appropriate to the setting of the story, that can loop in the background during phases where the players are allowed to run free and explore. For the more closely planned key scenes, I usually devote considerable time to finding just that right tune, sure to convey the right feeling and emotions to the scene. I generally try to avoid music with lyrics, unless it fits the story, such as if the PCs are attending a shady nightclub or a violent skinhead concert, or making the long drive to Russia with the right mixtapes blasting in the car stereo. As it so happens, most of the music in my tailored playlist is available on Spotify (except for some more obscure additions, unfortunately only available locally). Feel free to use it for your inspiration, or even your own games. It is available here: <https://open.spotify.com/playlist/3LSbQm17ysgMf5jER0v6j?si=55faba83f23747a3>
- ◆ Make good use of the available handouts, including the maps. I might add that for any of the editions, I've never understood the choice to include a map for Berlin and the Dream Leningrad, while leaving out maps for Moscow and the physical Leningrad. Centering the chapters in Germany around the Berlin map provided quite a lot in terms of orientation, and a tangible sense of the city and its different areas. In hindsight, I don't feel that I was as successful in making the Russian cities feel alive. Given the opportunity to play the game again, I would probably take the time to draw maps of Moscow and Leningrad as well.



- ◆ And finally: If I was to replay the campaign again, I would probably rewrite and reorganize the campaign from the PC's investigation of Slava in Moscow and onward. What really worked well in our campaign was the investigative element, where the PCs were invited to follow the trails of a dark past, unravelling deeply unsettling connections between malicious occultism, organized crime, and political extremism. To me, the ominous threat of these elements lost something of its edge when the PCs were physically put up against no less than two full military bases, armed to the teeth with trained soldiers, and even an actual Incarnate of a Death Angel. As far as possible, I like my games to have a realistic feel, where bullets are lethal, and death is bleak and final. It proved challenging to not turn the PCs into super heroes, or the soldiers into cross-eyed stormtroopers, in order to provide any hope of surviving against such odds. Having the KGB sorting out all the PCs' issues for them did not seem like an attractive option either. So if I was to replay the campaign, I would probably balance the first chapter in Russia

even more strongly toward espionage and infiltration, rather than high-level violence. Most likely, the battle against the military Incarnate would have played out in a very different way had I done it again.

I think that perhaps this is what can be said about the campaign in this retrospective, and relatively introspective, format. In discussion with one or more of the players that participated, it is likely that a different story may emerge. Most certainly, the experience was quite different for all of us. For me, it meant checking off a major box on the bucket list. It took several years to complete, but we made it happen.

To my players, Martin (Wolfgang),

Adde (Juno), Andreas (Sophia), I give my eternal thanks. This would most certainly not have been possible without you. I could never have wished for a more enthusiastic and devoted group of players, so thank you for giving your time and commitment to bring the story to life.

Thanks also to Helmgast for resurrecting KULT, and for presenting the Black Madonna in such a well-structured, manageable and complete way. And, of course, thanks to Gunilla Jonsson and Mikael Petersen for conceiving the original KULT, and penning the original Black Madonna scenario, among other amazing accomplishments. Your creation truly transcends time and space, and does not seem any less relevant today than when it was originally published.

It is March 2025, and Europe once again finds itself in the center of conflicting major powers. They hungrily tug and pull, longing to tear it apart and let their own spiritual Principles run unrestrained. The horrors of the past seem only too ready to step in and take over the reins when we invite them to do so.

Did anything really change?